

A woman wearing a headscarf is holding a baby. The image is in a dark, purple-toned style, with the woman's face and the baby's face being the primary light sources. The woman is looking directly at the camera with a serious expression. The baby is looking up towards the camera.

The Impact of Girls Education Restriction on Child Marriage in Afghanistan

A RIGHTS-BASED
ANALYSIS

June 2026



<https://womenrf.org/>

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ABOUT WRF

Women's Rights First (WRF) is an Afghan women-led organization dedicated to advancing the protection, documentation, and promotion of women's rights in Afghanistan through survivor-centered advocacy, accountability initiatives, and capacity building. Founded and led by Afghan women with backgrounds in international law, human rights, and governance, WRF works closely with women and girls inside Afghanistan to document violations, amplify lived experiences, and strengthen pathways to justice under international human rights and humanitarian law frameworks.

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY:

This report examines how restrictions on girls' education in Afghanistan have intensified the risk of child marriage by removing one of the strongest protective factors in girls' lives. Since the Taliban's return to power in August 2021, girls have been systematically excluded from secondary and higher education, and Afghanistan remains the only country in the world where girls and women are barred from secondary and university education.¹ UNICEF reported that by March 2025, 2.2 million girls had been denied secondary education, including nearly 400,000 additional girls excluded in preceding year ².

The scale of the underlying practice is already severe. UNICEF estimates that 28% of Afghan women aged 15–49 were married before the age of 18,³ and UN Women projects that, if the education bans persist,



¹ Human Rights Watch, "Afghanistan," in *World Report 2025* (New York: Human Rights Watch, 2025), <https://www.hrw.org/world-report/2025/country-chapters/afghanistan>.

² UNICEF, "As New School Year Starts in Afghanistan, Almost 400,000 More Girls Deprived of Their Right to Education, Bringing Total to 2.2 Million," March 21, 2025, <https://www.unicef.ca/en/press-release/new-school-year-starts-afghanistan-almost-400000-more-girls-deprived-their-right>.

³ UNICEF, "28 % of Afghan women aged 15–49 were married before the age of 18"; see UNICEF, "Girls Increasingly at Risk of Child Marriage in Afghanistan," November 12, 2021, <https://www.unicef.org/rosa/press-releases/girls-increasingly-risk-child-marriage-afghanistan>.

child marriage will rise by a further 25%, adolescent childbearing by 45%, and maternal mortality by at least 50%.⁴ These projections frame the central concern of this report: educational exclusion is not only a violation in itself but a measurable driver of child marriage and its downstream harms.

The report finds that the denial of education increases child marriage risk through several interrelated pathways. School often functions as a socially legitimate reason to delay marriage. The exclusion of girls from school intensifies economic pressure on households already living under crisis conditions. School closure also deepens girls' isolation and dependency, reducing their ability to seek support or resist pressure. At the same time, the removal of schools as institutions of visibility weakens protection and referral pathways that might otherwise identify risk.⁵ Interview evidence from girls affected by school exclusion reinforces these findings by showing

how restrictions are experienced in daily life and how they alter family expectations concerning marriage. The report concludes that restrictions on girls' education must be understood not only as violations of the right to education but also as catalysts for child marriage and as part of a wider pattern of gender discrimination recommends and harm. In UN agencies, States, and civil society actors adopt integrated responses that combine education advocacy, that donors, child protection, psychosocial support, legal accountability, and support for Afghan women-led and community-based organizations.

⁴UN Women, "Afghanistan: Ten Facts About the World's Most Severe Women's Rights Crisis," August 2025, <https://www.unwomen.org/en/news-stories/press-release/2025/08/afghanistan-ten-facts-about-the-worlds-most-severe-womens-rights-crisis>.

⁵Girls Not Brides, "Afghanistan," accessed May 14, 2026, <https://www.girlsnotbrides.org/learning-resources/child-marriage-atlas/regions-and-countries/afghanistan/>; UNICEF, "As New School Year Starts in Afghanistan."

2. METHODOLOGY

This report is based on desk review, legal analysis, and qualitative interviews with girls affected by school exclusion and child or early marriage. The desk review draws on international conventions and relevant legal instruments concerning education, child protection, discrimination, and child marriage, alongside current reporting from United Nations agencies and human rights organizations. Together, these sources provide both up-to-date data and legal and policy framing.

The interview component is qualitative and illustrative. It is not intended to establish national prevalence rates. Rather, it is used to illuminate how policy restrictions are experienced at the household and individual levels. Interview material has been anonymized and handled in accordance with safeguarding, confidentiality, informed consent, and referral protocols appropriate to work involving girls exposed to risk, coercion, or trauma.

The research team conducted in-depth interviews with 40 women drawn from 18 provinces of Afghanistan, capturing a range of regional, economic, and educational circumstances. All participants are identified in this report by pseudonyms; the names used throughout are not the real names of the women interviewed, and any potentially identifying details have been removed or altered to protect their safety. Interviews were conducted by voice, with consent, and transcribed and translated by the research team. Each transcript was then analysed using a thematic coding frame, in which segments of testimony were assigned to the six analytic themes that structure the Findings section: marriage risk, economic pressure, isolation and agency, protective pathways, physical and reproductive health, and psychological and emotional harm. Representative coded extracts are summarized and quoted within the Findings section, where each theme is developed alongside the testimony that supports it.



The background to this issue is also legal. Under international law, Afghanistan has obligations to ensure the right to education without discrimination and to protect children from harmful practices. The Convention on the Rights of the Child provides that every child has the right to education and that the best interests of the child must be a primary consideration.⁷ The Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women requires the elimination of discrimination against women and girls in education and public life.⁸ The International Economic, Social, and Cultural Rights recognizes the right to education and equality in its enjoyment.⁹

⁷United Nations, “Convention on the Rights of the Child,” 1989.

These Covenant on standards framework for understanding the current restrictions not simply as policy choices, but as violations of human rights principles. provide an essential Afghanistan's earlier domestic legal framework education also recognized marriage-related protections. The 2004 Constitution recognized education as the right of all citizens and required the State to foster education for women.¹⁰ The Afghan Civil Code set the minimum age of marriage at 16 for girls and 18 for boys, with limited exceptions for and girls conditions.¹¹ In addition, the Law on the Elimination of Violence Against Women formally recognized and aged 15 under specified criminalized under Article 28, providing that those underage marriage who marry or facilitate the marriage of an underage girl are subject to imprisonment.¹²

Although enforcement was inconsistent and harmful practices persisted, these rules recognition reflected a formal legal marriage that education was a protected right. The child required regulation and present restrictions, therefore, represent not

only a social regression but also a rupture with both domestic legal commitments and international norms. This statutory progress has been displaced by the recently published "Principles of Separation of "Spouses" (Osul-nama-ye Tafriq-e Zawjayn), signed by the Taliban supreme leader Hibatullah Akhundzada. This decree effectively legalizes and regulates child marriage, providing that if a relative beyond the father or grandfather marries off a minor, the contract is considered valid (Sahih) provided the parties are "equal" and the dowry is standard.¹³ Crucially, the decree mandates that a girl married in childhood who wishes to annul the marriage upon reaching puberty may do so only through a court order.

The current situation must also be understood within a broader pattern of severe restrictions on women's and girls' public lives. United Nations experts have reported that women and girls have been denied rights including education, work, health, freedom of movement, and freedom from discrimination.¹⁴ Human Rights Watch has similarly documented a broad pattern of abuses affecting women's and girls' lives.

⁸United Nations, "Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women," 1979, Art. 10, 16.

⁹United Nations, "International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights," 1966, Art. 13.

¹⁰Constitution of the Islamic Republic of Afghanistan [2004], Art. 43.

¹¹Civil Code of the Republic of Afghanistan, Art. 70, 71.

¹²Law on Elimination of Violence against Women [EVAW Law], Official Gazette No. 989 [2009], Art. 4 and 28.

in Afghanistan.¹⁵ In such a context, school exclusion contributes to a wider system of dependency and invisibility that leaves girls more vulnerable to pressure, coercion, and harmful outcomes, including child marriage.

4. STATISTICAL OVERVIEW

The figures below situate the report’s qualitative findings within the available quantitative picture. The most recent nationally representative source is the Afghanistan Multiple Indicator Cluster Survey (MICS) 2022–23, which provides survey-weighted estimates of marriage timing among women aged 20–24, disaggregated by province. Read against earlier surveys, these data reveal a clear three-phase trajectory: child marriage was extremely high before 2000, fell substantially over the following two decades, and now, since the return of restrictions in 2021, shows signs of rising again. The sections below trace each phase in turn.

Child Marriage in Afghanistan — The Trajectory
52% of girls ever-married at 15–19 in the 1970s — the historic high.
33% by 2016, after two decades of expanding education and programming.
28.7% married before 18 (9.6% before 15) — UNICEF MICS 2022–23.
39% in 2023 survey data — the post-2021 reversal underway.
+25% rise in child marriage since the 2021 takeover (UN Women).

¹³ *Osul-nama-ye Tafriq-e Zawjayn* [Principles of Separation of Spouses], Official Gazette, 2026.

¹⁴ Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights, “Afghanistan: UN Experts Say 20 Years of Progress for Women and Girls’ Rights Erased Since Taliban Takeover,” March 8, 2023,

<https://www.ohchr.org/en/press-releases/2023/03/afghanistan-un-experts-say-20-years-progress-women-and-girls-rights-erased>.

¹⁵ Human Rights Watch, “World Report 2025: Afghanistan.”

4.1 NATIONAL PICTURE: MICS 2022–23

The MICS 2022–23 reports child marriage through two complementary measures, and it is worth distinguishing them at the outset. The standard headline indicator — the share of all women who were married before 18 — is 28.7%, with 9.6% married before 15.¹⁶ The cohort-specific measure used throughout this section focuses only on women aged 20–24 (the United Nations’ recommended basis for tracking recent trends), among whom approximately 49% were first married or in union before 18. The two figures are not in conflict: the first averages across all age groups, while the second isolates the most recently married cohort, where prevalence is measured most precisely.



¹⁶UNICEF, *Afghanistan Multiple Indicator Cluster Survey (MICS) 2022–23* (Kabul: UNICEF, 2023), <https://mics.unicef.org/surveys>; survey-weighted estimates for women aged 20–24.

Breaking the 20–24 cohort down by age at first marriage shows how much of the burden falls in adolescence: nationally, 42.7% had never married, 7.1% married at 21–24, 21.6% at 18–20, 19.1% at 15–17, and 7.6% at 12–14, with a smaller share married before 12. In other words, more than a quarter of young women were married while still of school age, and a significant minority were married as very young adolescents. These distributions are shown in Figure 1.

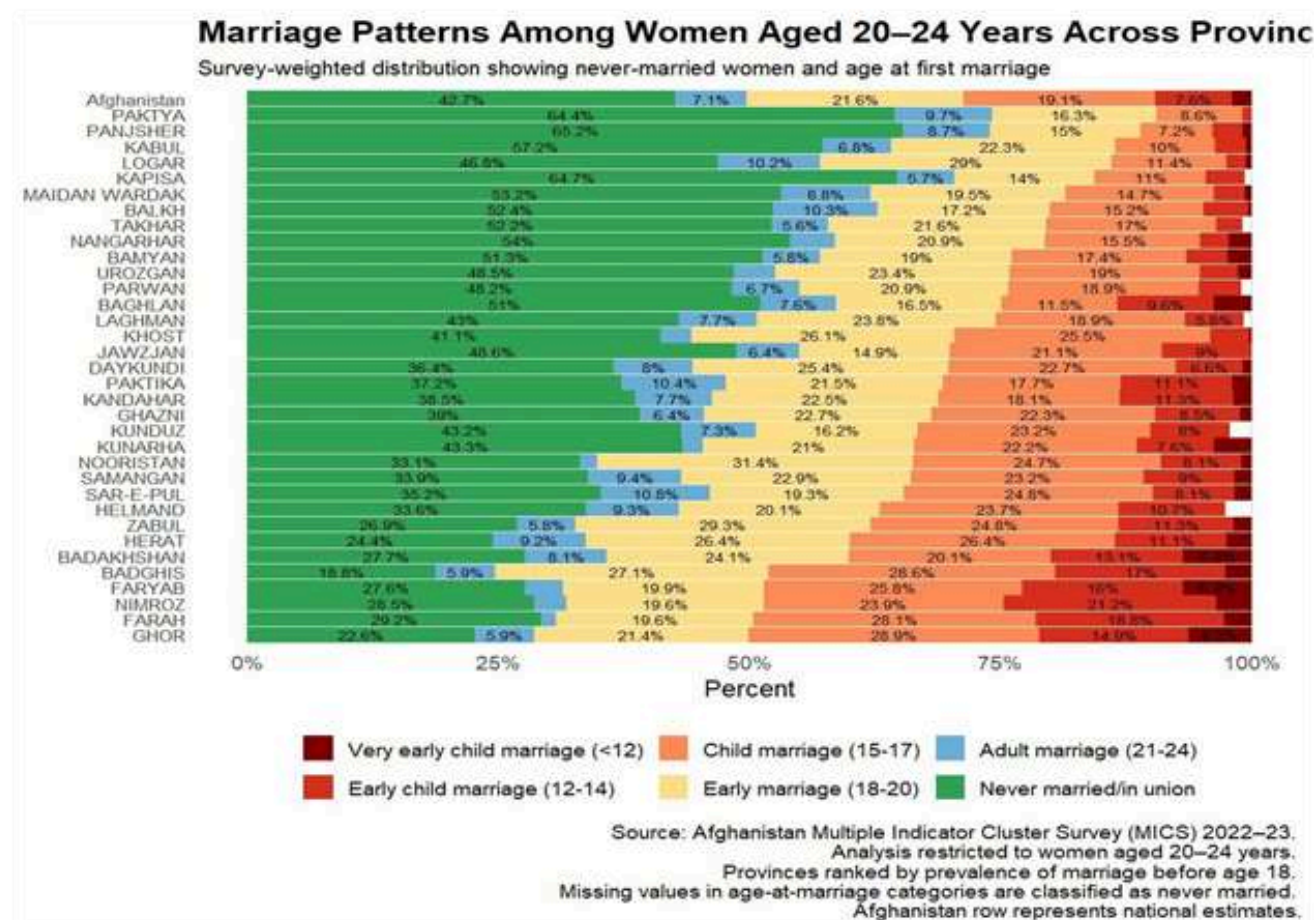


Figure 1. Marriage patterns among women aged 20–24, by province and age at first marriage.
Source: Afghanistan MICS 2022–23.

Aggregating all marriages before age 18 into a single measure (Figure 2) underscores both the national scale and the wide provincial variation. The national survey-weighted estimate is a near-even split, with about 49% of young women married as children and 51% as adults. Prevalence is lowest in provinces such as Paktya (22.6%), Logar (23.1%), and Parwan (32.4%), and highest in Helmand (64.1%), Herat (61.5%), and Faryab (58.7%). This range of more than forty percentage points reflects the close link between child marriage and local conditions of poverty, displacement, and access to schooling.

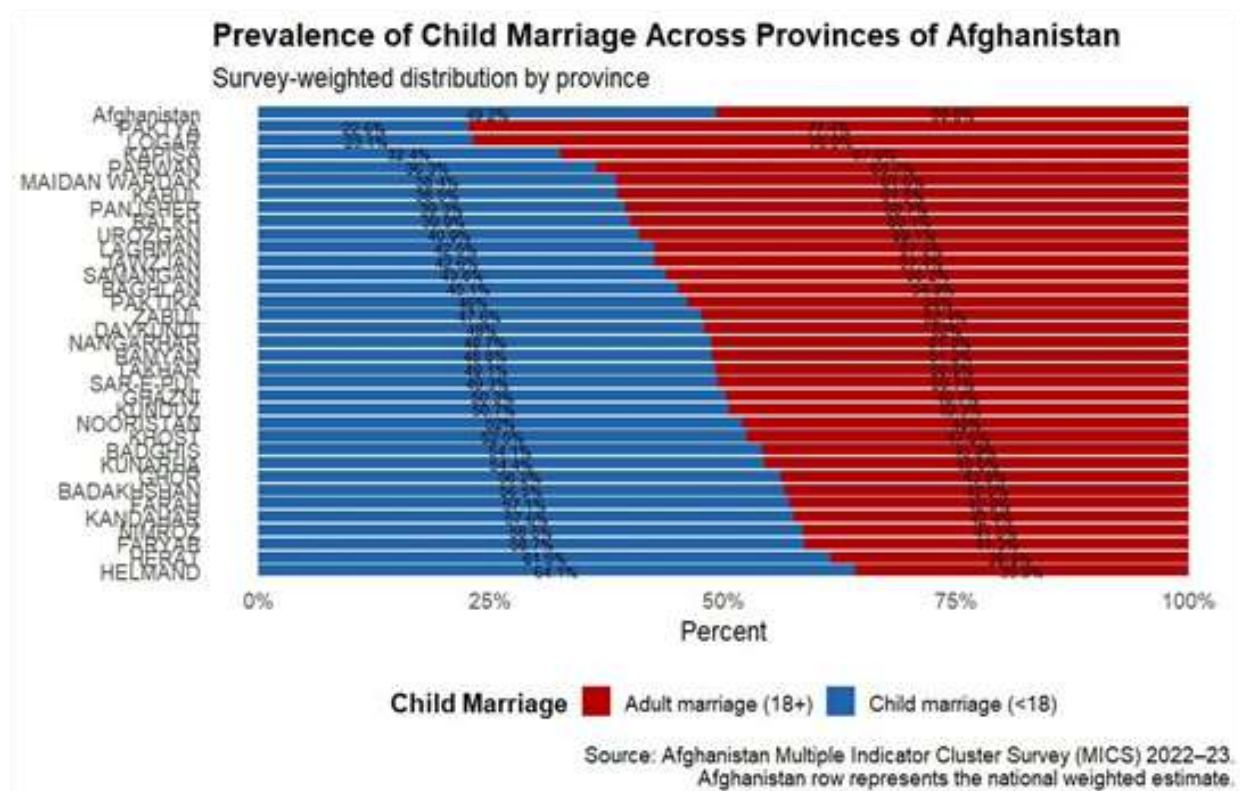


Figure 2. Prevalence of child marriage (before age 18) across provinces of Afghanistan.
Source: Afghanistan MICS 2022–23.

4.2 THE LONG-RUN TRAJECTORY: HIGH, THEN FALLING, NOW RISING.

Placing the MICS 2022–23 estimates alongside earlier data reveals a trajectory that rose, fell, and is now turning upward again (Figure 3), although the comparison requires care because surveys differ in method and definition. Before 2000, child marriage was pervasive. In the 1970s, an estimated 50 to 54% of girls had ever married between the ages of 15 and 19,¹⁷ and under the earlier Taliban regime in the 1990s, prevalence was reported as high as 62%.¹⁸ UNICEF’s long-run series records 46 per cent of girls marrying before 18 as of 1998.¹⁹

A sustained decline followed through the 2000s and 2010s. As the post-2001 period brought investment in girls’ education and child-protection programming, prevalence fell markedly: peer-reviewed analysis records a drop from the 62 % of the earlier era to about 33 % by 2016.²⁰



¹⁷Central Statistics Organization, Ministry of Public Health, and ICF, *Afghanistan Demographic and Health Survey 2015* (Kabul: CSO, 2017); see also O. Dadras et al., *Studies in Family Planning* 53, no. 3 (2022): 417–431.

¹⁸O. Dadras et al., “The Impact of Afghanistan’s Policies on Early Child Marriage and Girls’ Education: Current Trends and Future Consequences,” 2025; reporting child marriage at 62% under the earlier regime, ~33% by 2016, and a rise toward 39% in 2023.

¹⁹UNICEF, “Child Marriage in Afghanistan,” Child Marriage Data Portal, accessed 2026, <https://childmarriagedata.org/country-profiles/afghanistan/> (modelled series, 1998–2023).

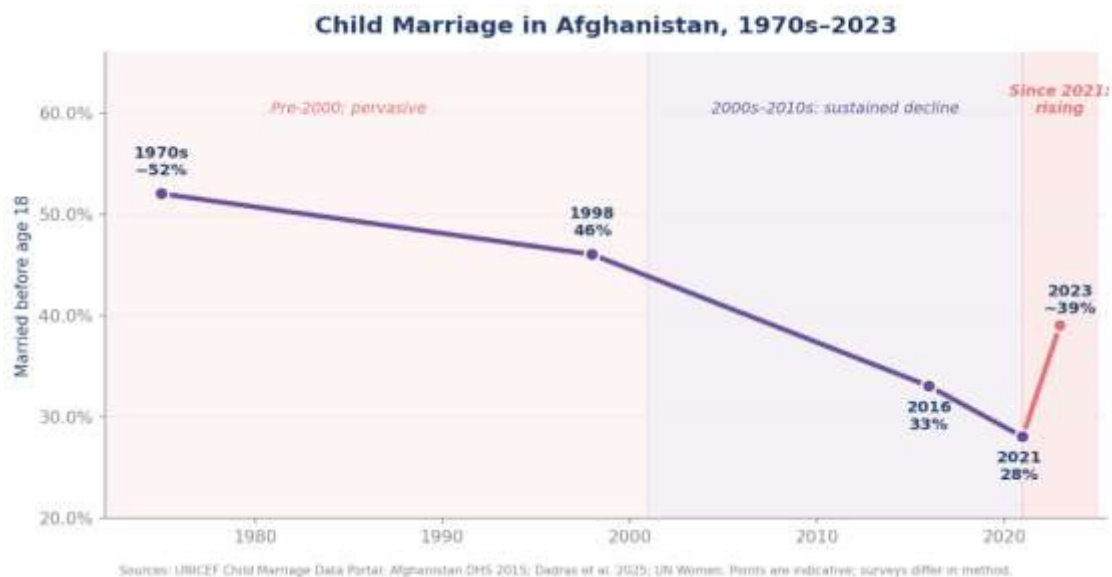


Figure 3. The trajectory of child marriage in Afghanistan, 1970s–2023: a long decline followed by a post-2021 reversal. Points are indicative and drawn from different surveys. Sources: UNICEF; DHS 2015; 2025; UN Women.

Nationally representative surveys anchor this decline. The 2015 Afghanistan Demographic and Health Survey found about 52% of women aged 20–24 had married before 18,²¹ and the Afghanistan Living Conditions Survey 2016–17 provided a further national benchmark over the same period.²² UNICEF’s modelled series likewise traces the fall from 46% in 1998 toward roughly 29% by 2023, and a 2021 UNICEF estimate put 28% of women aged 15–49 as married before 18.²³

The MICS 2022–23 headline figure of 28.7% married before 18, with 9.6% before 15, sits squarely within this range. The reduction was real, if uneven, and reflected the protective effect of expanding access to schooling, the very factor now being withdrawn.

²⁰ OHCHR, "Afghanistan: UN Experts"; Human Rights Watch, "Afghanistan."

²¹ UNICEF, "As New School Year Starts in Afghanistan."

²² Central Statistics Organization, *Afghanistan Living Conditions Survey 2016–17* (Kabul: CSO, 2018); see also UNICEF, "Statistical Profile on Child Marriage: Afghanistan."

²³ UNICEF, "As New School Year Starts in Afghanistan"; Girls Not Brides, "Afghanistan."

Since 2021, the trend has reversed. Multiple independent sources now document a renewed rise. UN Women estimates that child marriages have increased by approximately 25% since the Taliban takeover in August 2021,²⁴ and peer-reviewed analysis citing 2023 survey data reports prevalence climbing back toward 39%, which researchers attribute directly to the influence of governance on social norms.²⁵ An Afghan think-tank study found that 69% of respondents personally knew a girl married below the locally preferred age in reaction to the new restrictions,²⁶ while Amnesty International, Human Rights Watch, and Girls Not Brides have all documented increases in forced, early, and child marriage since 2021.²⁷ The MICS 2022–23 estimate of about 49% largely reflects marriages that occurred before this reversal could register, because most women in the 20–24 cohort married before 2021; the effect of the education bans will appear in future surveys as today’s school-age girls reach adulthood. Read against an already near 50% baseline, the projected 25% increase therefore points to a serious erosion of two decades of gains — with prevalence remaining highest, as throughout this history, among girls with no schooling and in the poorest households.



²⁴UN Women, “Afghanistan: Ten Facts About the World’s Most Severe Women’s Rights Crisis,” August 2025; see also RFE/RL, “Millions of Afghan Girls Barred From School,” March 2025.

²⁵ UNICEF, “Child Marriage in Afghanistan,” Child Marriage Data Portal,

²⁶Organization for Policy Research and Development Studies, study cited in NPR, “A New Taliban Law Opens the Door to Child Marriage Even Further,” May 2026 (69% of respondents knew a girl married below the preferred age).

²⁷Amnesty International, *Human Rights in Afghanistan* (2025); Human Rights Watch, “World Report 2025: Afghanistan”; Girls Not Brides, “Afghanistan.”

5. FINDINGS

The findings presented below are based on the desk review, legal analysis, and interview evidence. Together, they show how restrictions on girls' education in Afghanistan are shaping family decision-making, increasing vulnerability to child marriage, and weakening girls' protection and agency. Each finding pairs the analytic pattern with the testimony of the women interviewed, so that the lived experience and the mechanism are read together rather than apart.

The testimony quoted throughout this section is drawn from the wider set of interviews and presented under pseudonyms. These are not the women's real names, and identifying details have been removed for their safety. Lima was married at 15, while she was in grade 6, and became a mother at 16; Sana was married at 17 after being barred from continuing past grade 6; Housai and Taiba describe being pressed toward marriage once their schooling ended. Their accounts were coded against the report's six analytic themes; the table below maps each theme to the testimony that supports it, and the findings that follow develop each in turn.

Theme	Coded pattern	Illustrative testimony
4.1 Marriage risk	School closure directly preceded engagement and Taliban closed schools." (Lima) marriage	"I reached grade 6 when the
4.2 Economic pressure	Bride price and household hardship framed marriage as relief	"becoming an economic burden on my family" (Sana)
4.3 Isolation & agency	Loss of peers; refusal not possible	"No one listened or cared about what I wanted." (Taiba)
4.4 Protective pathways	No trusted adult outside the family to turn to	"There was no one I could talk to." (Taiba) married at 15,
4.5 Physical health	Early motherhood; pregnancy and childbirth as an adolescent	"became a mother at 16" (Lima)
4.6 Psychological harm	Depression, grief, shattered aspirations after leaving school	"My dreams were shattered." (Lima)

5.1 SCHOOL EXCLUSION AND MARRIAGE RISK

The central finding of this report is that the exclusion of girls from school functions as a direct driver of child marriage risk. Lack of access to education is one of the major drivers of child marriage in Afghanistan.²⁸ Schooling often provides girls with structure, social recognition, and a concrete reason to postpone marriage. It also supports future aspirations and gives families a

legitimate engagement basis for delaying marriage arrangements. When that pathway is removed, marriage may be reframed as the natural or only remaining option. Interview evidence strongly supports this described moment conclusion. Several girls the marriage-related discussions became more frequent or closure as when



²⁸Girls Not Brides, “Afghanistan.”

more serious within their households, and a shift in how they were spoken about — from being seen as students to being seen as ready for marriage. For Lima, the loss of school foreclosed clear ambitions she had held only shortly before. Before the Taliban came, I had many goals. I moved to Kabul to study and continue my education. I wanted to take English courses and become a doctor. ... I reached grade 6 when the Taliban closed schools.” — Lima, married at 15.

The sequence is important: marriage discussions accelerated around the loss of schooling and, once begun, could described not be reversed. Housai negotiation overtook her while she was still nominally a student “I left school three months before my engagement, although discussions about my marriage had already been ongoing for eight months. ... My family could not refuse the marriage because they had already agreed.” — Housai, married at 16.



5.2 ECONOMIC PRESSURE AND HOUSEHOLD COPING

A second major finding is that economic hardship intensifies the impact of school exclusion on marriage decisions.

Afghanistan's ongoing humanitarian crisis has deepened poverty, insecurity, and a second major finding is that economic hardship intensifies the impact of school exclusion on marriage decisions.

Afghanistan's ongoing humanitarian crisis has deepened poverty, insecurity, and household stress.

UNICEF has warned that millions of girls remain excluded from education while the broader crisis continues to undermine resilience.²⁹ In such settings, marriage may be seen by some families as a strategy to reduce economic burden, secure social uncertainty support, or respond to of education reinforces this logic by narrowing girls' future opportunities and weakening the practical case for continued delay. The removal interview findings illustrate how this dynamic is experienced. Once schooling ended, family conversations increasingly reflected financial anxiety and the perception that no alternatives remained.

Marriage was not always described as a cultural preference alone, but as something tied to hardship, dependency, and the closing of other doors. Sana described how the bride price negotiated over her left no room to refuse, and located her marriage squarely in the family's economic strain.

"Initially, the bride price (walwar) was set at 800,000 Afghanis, but it was later reduced to 400,000. ... My family could not refuse the marriage because they had already agreed." — Sana, married at 17. "I didn't want to get married but didn't have any other options. I was not allowed to go to school above grade 6 and was becoming an economic burden on my family." — Sana, married at 17. These testimonies suggest that the connection between education restriction and child marriage cannot be understood apart from the political and economic context in which families are making decisions.

²⁹UNICEF, "As New School Year Starts in Afghanistan."

5.3 ISOLATION, DEPENDENCY, AND REDUCED AGENCY

A third finding is that school exclusion deepens girls' isolation and reduces their agency. Schools are not only places of learning; they are also social spaces where girls remain visible to peers, teachers, and support networks. At the same time, women and girls in Afghanistan are subject to restrictions on movement and participation in public life.³⁰ In combination, these constraints leave girls increasingly confined to the household and dependent on family decision-makers, reducing their ability to negotiate, seek advice, or resist unwanted marriage. Interviewed girls repeatedly described the emotional and social effects of losing school: the loss of daily contact with friends and teachers, loneliness, and a sense that their lives had been paused. Several explained that once they were no longer attending school, they had fewer people to turn to and less

confidence in expressing their wishes. Taiba's words capture both the severance of her social world and the absence of anyone who would hear her.

"Since leaving school, I lost contact with all my classmates. ... There was no one I could talk to. No one listened or cared about what I wanted." — Taiba, married at 16. Reduced agency, these accounts show, is felt in everyday decisions, silences, and constraints rather than in any single moment of refusal.

³⁰OHCHR, "Afghanistan: UN Experts"; Human Rights Watch, "Afghanistan."

5.4 COLLAPSE OF PROTECTIVE PATHWAYS

Exclusion systems that might otherwise help prevent child marriage. Teachers, school administrators, and education staff can serve as early warning points when girls face distress, pressure, or risk of abuse. Once girls are removed from school, a finding is that school protective mechanisms are undermined. Those institutional contact points disappear. UNICEF has emphasized that community-based learning can help mitigate some harm, but formal exclusion on a national scale leaves large numbers of girls outside regular systems of visibility and support.³¹

Interview evidence reflects this loss. Some girls stated that before school closure they could speak with teachers or trusted adults outside the family, while afterward they felt confined to family spaces where pressure could not easily be challenged.

Others explained that they no longer had access to information or encouragement that might have helped them imagine alternatives. The result is not only fewer educational opportunities, but fewer protection opportunities: risk becomes harder to detect, and girls facing pressure may have no safe path to disclosure.

³¹UNICEF, “As New School Year Starts in Afghanistan.”

5.5 HARM TO PHYSICAL AND REPRODUCTIVE HEALTH

A Fifth finding concerns the physical and reproductive consequences of this cumulative, and long-term. Child marriage is closely associated with pattern, which are severe, early pregnancies, heightened risks during childbirth, and exposure to physical violence within the household. In a closely spaced Afghanistan magnified by one of the highest maternal mortality rates in the world and by restrictions that limit women's access to female health workers, midwifery training, and reproductive care.³² Girls who marry and bear children before their bodies and these dangers are circumstances are ready face elevated risks to their own survival and to that of their infants, and those risks fall hardest in the rural and impoverished settings where child marriage is most common.

Interview evidence reflects how early these physical harms begin. Lima was

married at 15 and became a mother at 16, entering pregnancy and childbirth while still an adolescent and while cut off from the education and services that might have supported her. Her experience illustrates the report's broader finding that the removal of girls from school accelerates a sequence — marriage, early pregnancy, and constrained access to care — in which each step compounds the physical risk of the next. The effects are borne not only by individual girls, but also by their future children, their families, and their communities.

³²Human Rights Watch, "World Report 2025: Afghanistan," December 18, 2024,

<https://www.hrw.org/world-report/2025/country-chapters/afghanistan>.

5.6 PSYCHOLOGICAL AND EMOTIONAL HARM

A psychological and emotional toll of school exclusion and early marriage is profound, and that it begins well before any marriage takes place. Loss of education removes not only a pathway to the future but also a daily source of structure, recognition, and hope. Several participants described anxiety, fear, shame, sadness, and a sense that their lives had been paused or emptied of meaning once sixth finding is that the their education ended.

Some associated the pressure to marry with acute distress and a loss of dignity, and others described the feeling that their own wishes had become irrelevant. Lima, who became a mother at 16, described a period of depression after leaving school. “I kept asking myself what I would do with my life. My dreams were shattered. I wanted to have my own agency, to work, and to build my future.” — Lima, married at 15

Her words capture how the foreclosure of education is experienced not merely as a lost opportunity but as a grief. These testimonies underscore that the consequences of school exclusion are psychological and emotional as well as physical, legal, and material, and that mental-health support belongs alongside protection and education in any adequate response.

5.7 IN THEIR OWN WORDS: WHAT THE GIRLS ASK FOR

Across themselves identified what would make the greatest difference to their lives. Their priorities centred on the restoration of access to education, whether through the reopening of the interviews, the girls schools community-based or safe alternative learning, and on protection from forced and early marriage, and on recognition of their own voice in decisions about their futures. They expressed a continuing desire to learn and a determination that the next generation should not face the same closure of opportunity. These priorities are reflected directly in the recommendations that follow.

“If I have children, I will make sure they receive an education. Schools should be open so that girls can continue their studies.”

— Lima, married at 15

“I still want to continue my education, but girls above grade 6 are not allowed to attend courses.”

— Sana, married at 17

6. POLICY IMPLICATIONS

The evidence reviewed in this report demonstrates that restrictions on girls' education in Afghanistan are increasing the risk of child marriage through reinforcing multiple and pathways mutually. School exclusion removes a recognized reason to delay marriage, deepens economic isolation, vulnerability, increases protective systems, and narrows girls' ability to shape their own futures. Interview weakens testimony confirms that these processes are already unfolding in the lives of affected girls.

Girls' education must therefore be treated not merely as an educational issue, but as a child protection, gender justice, and international legal responsibility issue. Policies and programmes that fail to connect school exclusion with child protection risk underestimating the scale and consequences of harm, including child marriage and other forms of vulnerability.

Effective require strategies integrated, that link responses rights-based education, adolescent protection, psychosocial support, health services, and family- level economic assistance,³³ while remaining attentive to the lived realities of girls whose access to education has been denied.

For donors, this means supporting flexible, multi-sectoral programming rather than narrowly defined education projects. For UN agencies, it means coordinating advocacy and response protection, across the education, gender clusters. For the broader international community, it means maintaining principled pressure on the Taliban health, and authorities while strengthening organisations and community-based protection efforts.

³³UNICEF, "As New School Year Starts in Afghanistan"; ³⁴Human Rights Watch, "Afghanistan"; OHCHR, "Girls Not Brides, "Afghanistan. "Afghanistan: UN Experts.

7. RECOMMENDATIONS

7.1 FOR DONORS

- Fund integrated education, child protection, psychosocial support, and child marriage prevention initiatives.
- Support flexible, multi-year funding for local organisations that can reach girls outside formal schools.
- Invest in evidence generation and qualitative research documenting the links between school exclusion and child marriage.

7.2 FOR UN AGENCIES

- Frame girls' education as both a rights issue and a child protection priority.
- Strengthen identification and referral systems for girls at risk of early marriage.
- Expand safe alternative learning pathways while maintaining pressure for full restoration of formal education rights.

7.3 FOR INTERNATIONAL

- Maintain coordinated diplomatic pressure to reverse restrictions on girls' education.
- Support accountability initiatives addressing gender-based persecution and harmful practices.
- Ensure Afghan women-led organisations are included in policy, advocacy, and funding processes.

8. CONCLUSION

Restrictions on girls' education in Afghanistan are contributing to child marriage by removing one of the most effective protective structures in girls' lives. This is not only a legal or administrative problem; it is a social one with direct consequences for safety, autonomy, and future opportunity. Once girls are forced out of school, they face greater pressure from poverty, dependency, isolation and weak protection systems, all of which make early marriage more likely. The report's conclusion is therefore well grounded: school exclusion and child marriage must be addressed together.

The harms extend beyond marriage itself. Child marriage is linked to interrupted education, early pregnancy, domestic violence, mental distress, and reduced economic independence. In Afghanistan, those effects are intensified by restrictions

on movement, work, and access to public life, which can leave married girls with very few routes back into education or community support. A girl who is both married and out of school may be pushed close to total exclusion from public life, with consequences that last well into adulthood. The practical response must be coordinated and rights-based: legal advocacy, protection programming, education access, and support for girls' autonomy need to move together rather than separately.



Women's Rights First

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